

GitHub, LinkedIn, and public artifacts

Week 2, Lecture 2 · Landing the Offer: SWE Job Search for Senior CS Students

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- The three public surfaces that hiring managers check before an interview
- How to write a project README that functions as marketing, not documentation
- LinkedIn specifically for SWE: what to fill in and what to skip
- Pinned repositories as a curated portfolio
- Blog posts, demos, and write-ups as attention surfaces beyond the resume

Part 1: the three public surfaces

Three surfaces, one consistent story

Your public presence runs in parallel with your resume. By the time a recruiter schedules a call, they have usually looked at:

1. **GitHub profile** (contributions, pinned repos, README quality)
2. **LinkedIn profile** (headline, experience, activity)
3. **A public artifact** if one appeared in your resume or was findable

These three surfaces either confirm the resume's story or contradict it. (Tay, 2023)

Why public surfaces matter more than you expect

- Luu (2015): hiring decisions rely heavily on signals that correlate with but do not prove ability. Public work is one of the few ways to override a weak credential signal with a direct demonstration.
- A well-maintained GitHub profile with working projects and readable code is evidence, not decoration
- McKenzie (2011): "companies converge on doing things which increase revenue or reduce costs." A public project that solves a real problem is a direct demonstration of that value.

Part 2: GitHub portfolio

The GitHub profile page

Three things a hiring manager notices first:

1. **Contribution graph** (is this person coding regularly or in bursts?)
2. **Pinned repositories** (up to six; these are your curated portfolio)
3. **Profile README** (opt-in; a markdown file in a repo named after your username)

A sparse contribution graph is not a deal-breaker, but a well-maintained one at the new-grad level is a positive signal with almost no downside cost.

README as marketing, not documentation

A good project README answers five questions in order:

1. What problem does this solve? (one sentence)
2. Who would use it? (one sentence)
3. How do I run it right now? (code block, copy-paste ready)
4. What does it look like? (a screenshot or GIF if applicable)
5. What is the interesting technical decision? (one paragraph)

The fifth question is the one that opens interview conversations. It frames the project's narrative for a 30-second scan.

Pinned project selection

Pin the projects that:

- Have a working demo, a live URL, or at least a screenshot
- Contain code you would be comfortable discussing for 20 minutes in an interview
- Show range: avoid pinning six versions of the same type of project
- Have clean READMEs that pass the five-question test

Do not pin: forks you did not materially contribute to, half-finished coursework with no README, or private repos left public by accident.

Contribution quality over contribution count

- One merged pull request to a real open-source project with a clear description signals more than 200 commits to a personal toy project
- Code review comments and issue discussions are visible and contribute to the profile narrative
- Keep commit messages informative ("Add pagination to /users endpoint" not "fix stuff")
- Tay (2023): the GitHub portfolio is part of the resume checklist for FAANG-tier applications

Part 3: LinkedIn for SWE

What to fill in and what to skip

Fill in:

- Headline: not your job title, your positioning ("Backend engineer seeking new-grad SWE roles, Python and Go")
- Experience section: mirror your resume bullets, not a prose summary
- Skills: list technologies; they feed LinkedIn's keyword search for recruiters
- Education: complete with graduation date

Skip or minimize:

- Endorsements from people who have not worked with you
- "Open to work" banner if you are currently employed

LinkedIn as an inbound channel

Recruiters at technical companies search LinkedIn by keyword and graduation year. To appear in those searches:

- Include the specific technology names from your target job descriptions
- Set "Open to Work" (visible to recruiters only, not your network) during active search
- A recent, professional photo increases profile view rates in studies McKenzie (2011) cites about first-impression signals

Outbound use (cold messages to recruiters) is covered in Week 9. For now, optimize for being found.

Activity and posts on LinkedIn

- Posting is optional; not posting is not a negative signal for most SWE roles
- If you do post: project updates, write-ups, or observations from your coursework are higher signal than reshared motivational content
- Commenting thoughtfully on posts by people at target companies occasionally surfaces your profile to their connections
- Consistency matters more than frequency: one substantive post per month beats ten shallow ones

Part 4: public artifacts

What counts as a public artifact

A public artifact is any piece of work that:

- Lives at a public URL
- Demonstrates something about how you think or build
- Can be discovered by a recruiter or hiring manager without a warm introduction

Examples: a technical blog post, a live demo, a write-up published to a personal site or dev.to, a conference talk slide deck, a detailed GitHub issue you opened and resolved.

The project narrative frame

The goal of a public artifact is not completeness. It is narrative.

A write-up of 500 words that answers "what problem did you solve, what did you try, and what did you learn?" does more positioning work than a 5,000-line codebase with no README.

Frame the project's narrative for a 30-second scan: problem, decision, result. A reader who is interested will go deeper. A reader who is not will at least remember that you think clearly.

(Inoue, 2020)

Blog posts and demos as attention surfaces

- A technical blog post that ranks in search results for a narrow query ("how I debugged a race condition in Node.js") can surface your profile to engineers at target companies who searched that query
- A live demo with a clear "how I built this" link is a richer signal than a GitHub repo alone
- One good artifact published and linked from your resume is better than five half-done ones
- Luu (2015): concrete accomplishments that bypass credential signals are available to any candidate willing to do the work

Connecting the surfaces to the resume

Your resume, GitHub, LinkedIn, and public artifacts should tell the same story from four angles:

- Resume: accomplishment bullets with metrics
- GitHub: readable code and a working project
- LinkedIn: findable by the right keyword searches
- Public artifact: the "how I think" layer that no other surface can carry

When a recruiter reads your resume and then opens your GitHub and finds exactly what the resume describes, that confirmation builds trust.

If your type is the same type everyone else is competing for, you are competing for talent with the wealthiest companies in the market.

<footer>Dan Luu, "We only hire the trendiest," 2015</footer>

Take-aways

1. Three public surfaces run in parallel with your resume: GitHub, LinkedIn, and at least one public artifact. They should confirm the same story.
2. A README answers five questions in order: problem, user, how to run, screenshot, and the interesting technical decision. The fifth opens interview conversations.
3. Pin 3-6 projects that have working demos, readable code, and complete READMEs. Avoid forks you did not materially change.
4. LinkedIn is primarily an inbound channel for new grads. Fill in headline, experience, and skills for recruiter keyword search.
5. One substantive public artifact outperforms ten sparse ones. Frame the project narrative for a 30-second scan.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 2 reading covers all of today's material plus worked examples (read before section)
- **Section (this week):** Resume teardown clinic and public artifact sketch
- **HW 1 (out week 1, due week 3):** Resume and portfolio audit; today's surfaces are what you will audit
- **Week 3:** Coding interview format and the first two patterns